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SPECIAL REPORT



GREAT WASTE IN THE GREAT LAKES

As plastics clog the waters, industry presses to make more and downplays dangers, Tribune analysis finds

By Michael Hawthorne | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

ERIE, Pa. — On an overcast day in this Great Lakes city, semitrucks pulled alongside railcars parked at a tree-lined siding. One by one, drivers jumped out, connected thick hoses from underneath their trailers and vacuumed up shipments from the Gulf Coast and Ohio River Valley.

Reporting for this story was supported by the Pulitzer Center's StoryReach U.S. initiative.

Sherri Mason sifted through what they left behind: Amidst the gravel rail bed, thousands of translucent white pellets littered the ground, throwaways from American industry's insatiable appetite for plastic.

"Like stars in the night sky," Mason, a Gannon University educator and researcher who goes by Sam, said as she waved a hand above the detritus. "Seemingly beautiful, until you realize what they are."

Then she nodded toward nearby storm drains that flush unfiltered into Lake Erie, one of five freshwater seas sustaining more than 40 million people in the United States and Canada.

More plastic bits, each barely larger than a grain of rice, scattered across asphalt outside a stop on delivery routes from the railroad.

Plastic pellets, also known as nurdles, are manufactured by petrochemical plants specifically for the purpose of making new products. At least 15 factories here melt and mold the raw materials into water bottles, yogurt cups, fast-food packaging and scores of other goods.

Erie is among hundreds of communities in the U.S. and Canada where nurdles spill into the Great Lakes from chemical plants that make them, trains and trucks that transport them and factories that turn them into consumer products.

Untouched by everyday people, nurdles that don't get used in the manufacturing process, either because of wasteful transportation or production practices, are write-offs for global oil and chemical conglomerates plotting to dramatically expand the use of plastic in every aspect of life.

When confronted about their pollution, industry executives often have blamed consumers, using tactics borrowed from and shared with Big Tobacco, according to a Chicago Tribune review of thousands

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Above: Sherri Mason, a Gannon University researcher, picks up plastic pellets, pieces barely larger than a grain of rice, that litter the ground where they are transferred from rail cars to trucks and delivered to local manufacturers in Erie, Pennsylvania. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE**

Volunteers help immigrants get home after freed by ICE

Some held near their communities, but many sent to other states

By Gregory Royal Pratt
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

After being released from nine months in Immigration and Customs Enforcement detention, Jesus Ramirez Ramos needed help.

The clothes he wore when he was arrested stank from spending the better part of a year in storage, unwashed. ICE lost his cell-

phone at the Michigan jail where he was held, cutting off important contacts. He was arrested and detained far from his Salina, Kansas, home, and had no easy way back to the nation's heartland.

Or so he thought. When he walked out of the North Lake detention center in Baldwin, a small town in northern Michigan, Delight Lester was there.

A 66-year old Michigander, Lester is involved with an advocacy group that fills ICE detain-

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Larry Gephart, right, assists Jose Angel Miranda, of Nicaragua, who was released from the North Lake Processing Center in Baldwin, Michigan, with a phone call from an attorney outside the facility on May 14. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

ILLINOIS LEGISLATURE

Racing to finalize \$55 billion budget

Bears stadium talks take back seat on final day of legislative session

By Rick Pearson, Jeremy Gerner, Dan Petrella, Olivia Olander and Jack O'Connor
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SPRINGFIELD — With one day left before their scheduled month-end adjournment deadline, Illinois state lawmakers Saturday worked to put together a limited package of tax increases and revenue diversions to finance a new state budget of more than \$55 billion. Finding agreement on a plan aimed at keeping the Chicago Bears in Illinois continued to be elusive.

Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker and the Democrats who lead supermajorities in the House and Senate, House Speaker Emanuel "Chris" Welch and Senate President Don Harmon, used the day to follow the advice and admonition that late Republican Gov. Jim Edgar once gave to Pritzker — that the governor's most "important job is to pass a balanced budget."

Talks on the fate of the Bears — who are being lured by a taxpayer-financed stadium package in Hammond, Indiana — and a proposal to allow the team to negotiate local property taxes for a site it purchased in the northwest suburb of Arlington Heights continued but were a lower priority than the budget. However, representatives

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INSIDE



JOAN MARCUS

Theater in Chicago heats up for summer

After a customary late-May lull, Chicago's theater gets back into action in June with several lively summer offerings, ranging from new musicals with star-encrusted casts to an in-the-round Sondheim to an experimental vampire show. **Arts & Entertainment**

Middle East awaits decision on war deal

President Donald Trump said he was meeting with advisers to make a "final determination" about a proposed deal with Iran. **Nation & World, Page B5**

Sox rolling, but now without Murakami

The Sox hit three home runs — without Munetaka Murakami, who is out with a hamstring injury — extending their winning streak to four games. **Sports**

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